crisis at the Occidental Restaurant. Indeed, he suggested that neither he nor Scali made any attempt to formulate a solution over their lunch. Instead, it was the American journalist who made the proposal at their follow-up meeting at the Statler Hotel. Scali, who was present at the Moscow conference, strongly disputed Feklisov's account. So, who to believe? An American journalist or a Soviet intelligence officer? Can their accounts somehow be reconciled? Michael Dobbs argues that 'What Scali and the Americans interpreted as a feeler from Moscow, was in reality an attempt by his KGB contact to identify Washington's conditions for ending the crisis.'[32] Or, could Feklisov have sought to disguise his own initiative by attributing the proposal to Scali? This might well sound professionally prudent for a career-minded member of the KGB's First Chief Directorate. Yet, thirty years on, and well into retirement, Feklisov still insisted on denying himself a place in the history books.

Aleksandr Fursenko and Timothy Naftali provide detailed accounts based on unique access to Soviet records, including KGB paper-trails in Moscow. They present carefully nuanced assessments that clarify some key issues (but not all). In 1995 they concluded that Feklisov's cables to Moscow on 26 and 27 October, together with evidence of how the KGB handled them, 'suggest strongly that the Soviet government did not initiate the proposals that Scali presented to Rusk on the afternoon of October 26'.[33] Moreover, they argued, 'The KGB materials substantiate claims that for the Kremlin, the Scali-Feklisov meetings were a sideshow that played no part in the U.S.-Soviet endgame of October 26-28.'[34] Instead, 'The story of the Scali-Feklisov back-channel remains significant as a prime example of how governments can misinterpret each other, especially in the grip of a crisis.'[35] It might be added that if that was the case, misinterpretation on the US side played a positive, albeit minor, role.

However, in their 2006 book, *Khrushchev's Cold War,* Fursenko and Naftali provide a different perspective; one that takes interpretation back to square one. They suggest that Scali's account of the lunch was more credible than that of Feklisov. Moreover, their conclusion (for some reason buried away in their endnotes) is that the Presidium's acceptance of Khrushchev's proposal to withdraw the missiles on 25 October